First Congregational Church of St. Albans (FCC) is a welcoming community of spiritual seekers, believers, and doubters.

Please know that no *matter who you are or where you are on life's journey, you're welcome here.*

First Congregational Church Vision Statement

To create an open and loving community that encourages a joyous exploration with God.
To work together to care for and nurture the wider community.

First Congregational Church Mission Statement

Our mission as a community resource church is to provide a safe place for spiritual exploration and personal growth. To affirm the value of each person and to meet them where they are.
To connect to the community through personal service, giving, and pastoral care.

Please feel free to contact us:
Administrative Office: 8-12 Tuesday, 8-10 Wednesday,
8-12 Thursday and 9-12 Friday.
Church Office Phone Number: 802-524-4555
Pastor Jessica's Office Hours: T-W-F, 9am-12pm
Email: pastorjessica@firstcongregationalstalbans.org
For urgent, pastoral matters outside of regular office hours,
call Pastor Jessica at 207-632-5544.

Our worship service is broadcast over the local public access channel 1079 on Sundays at 4 PM.

Scripture Reader: Louise Haynes

UNITED CHURCH OF CHRIST

First Congregational Church of St. Albans

An open and affirming community.



"We welcome you and serve all through faith."

Worship with us:

September 3, 2023

9:00 am

Rev. Jessica Moore, Pastor
Erin Grainger, Music and Choral Director
Stephan Conrady, Organist
Monica Newton, Office Manager
27 Church Street, St. Albans, VT 05478
802-524-4555

info@firstcongregationalstalbans.org
www.firstcongregationalstalbans.org

We Gather as God's People

Centering Words:

A confrontation, most importantly one with ourselves, is what needs to take place in order for true awareness, change, and healing to occur.

Kristina Smeriglio

THE PREPARATION

Prelude: *Wedding Waltz* S. Conrady

Welcome and Announcements

Morning Prayer [1] **(Unison)**

Eternal God, when we search for you, we find you. When we seek you, we find you seeking us. Your presence among us changes our circumstances and our lives. We honor and worship you as an act of devotion and discipleship. Infuse us with your Spirit that our witness and ministry may be a testimony to your everlasting love. Amen.

Hymn*

"God Is Here! As We Your People" (1, 2, 4) NCH 70

Welcome to all visitors: We are delighted that you chose to worship with us today and are strengthened by your participation in our service!

If you are new to First Congregational Church of St. Albans, please sign the guest book in the narthex (main entrance of the church).

If you would like more information about our church and its programs or would like to receive our Morning Reflections, and weekly e-newsletter, "From the Manse," please fill out a Welcome Card and place it in the Offering tray (be sure to include your email address).

After the service please join us for fellowship, conversation, coffee, and refreshments.

*Please Stand If You Are Able

[1] UCC Worship Ways

Music, Copyright permissions: CCLI #4799426 and SJMP #14586

They are like trees planted by streams of water, which yield their fruit in its season. Psalm1:3a



Rooted in love

Our Stewardship theme of "Rooted in Love" draws inspiration from Psalm 1, "They are like trees planted by streams of water, which yield their fruit in its season." The Psalmist invited us to imagine all the good things we can bear when well planted. What might we give away when rooted in love?

But the Psalmist also meant something deeper. The word we translate as "planted" in English means "transplanted" in Hebrew. This translation speaks to the power of love to move us from one place to another, the power to convert us from one way of life to another. What would need to change in our lives for us to be fully rooted in love?

We might need to make a move from a "mindset of scarcity" to a "mindset of abundance." A scarcity mindset makes us think there will never be enough - we must compete, one against another, because there is not enough to go around. Scarcity thinking names all the things we cannot do, all the things we cannot share. But a mindset of abundance sees the fullness of God's love. Martin Luther King Jr. saw the world abundantly – despite all the injustice he confronted,

King knew God's spirit moved through history, creating and renewing community. King once described the force of love that animated the Civil Rights Movement. "Agape is not a weak, passive love. It is love in action. Agape is love seeking to preserve and create community. It is insistence on community even when one seeks to break it. Agape is a willingness to go to any length to restore broken community.

What would it mean for our lives to be rooted in such love?

Prayer of Confession[1] **(Unison)**

Forgiving God, we acknowledge that repentance opens the door to forgiveness and transformation. We turn from our desire for comfort over compassion, easy solutions or challenging resolution, and avoidance over confrontation. We need your strength, fortitude, and conviction to overcome our fear of loss to make room for the gains of new life for ourselves and our neighbors through our generous and sacrificial living.

Pause for Reflection

Words of Assurance

Passing of the Peace

THE MESSAGE

Special Music *Ludus Tonalis* S. Conrady

Scripture Reading

Exodus 3: 1-15
Romans 12: 9-21

Morning Reflection: "Our Love Roots"

Hymn*
"Let Us Break Bread Together" NCH 330

THE COMMUNION Blue Binder

THE THANKSGIVING

Sharing Our Joys and Concerns

Pastoral Prayer ~

OFFERTORY

Doxology

Praise God from whom all blessing flow
Praise God all creatures here below;
Praise God above, all heavenly hosts:
Creator, Christ and Holy Ghost. Amen.

Offertory Prayer

THE DEPARTURE

Hymn*

"Great Is Your Faithfulness" NCH 423

Benediction

Postlude *Improvisation on "Dies Irae"* S. Conrady

Announcements:

A Special Note of Gratitude From All of Us At FCC:

- Sue Powers Thank You for volunteering in the office last week!

SEPTEMBER 10th
Worship returns to 10am

Sept. 10 @ 10am
Breakfast Church
Join in the fun!
Everyone is welcome for this casual worship service! We will worship in the Chapel while sharing breakfast. We will pray, praise, share, and sing over delicious food and coffee!
All ages welcome!

Church Street Sounds of the Season
Sept. 10 @ 3pm
Sounds of the Season returns with its annual organ concert featuring Vaughn Watson of the Vermont Organ Guild.
Donations go to First Congregational Church's Organ Fund

Open Mic
September 16
7-9pm
Everyone is welcome: beginners, experts and everyone

September 10th after church:
Notice of Informational Meeting
for Congregation Members and Friends
Everyone is welcome!